# USA: Q3 GDP Somewhat Above Expectations; Core PCE in Line with Expectations; Launching Q4 GDP Tracking at +1.8%

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**BOTTOM LINE:** Real GDP grew 3.4% annualized in the third quarter, somewhat above consensus expectations, and the composition was strong. Consumer spending rose 3.8% annualized, above expectations. The consumer has remained resilient this year despite headwinds from higher energy prices, but we expect spending growth to slow from its recent rapid pace as the boost from fiscal stimulus earlier in the year fades completely and spending converges to the pace of real income growth. Nonresidential fixed investment rose 12.7% annualized, reflecting sharp increases in the information processing and industrial equipment components related to the AI buildout. The core PCE price index rose 0.32% in September, in line with expectations, and the year-over-year rate increased 3.12%. We estimate that the Dallas Fed's trimmed mean PCE measure increased 0.23% month-over-month and 2.27% year-over-year. Initial claims decreased by 1k to 194k in the week ended October 24, slightly below consensus expectations. The four-week moving average of claims now stands at its lowest level since 1969. We launched our Q4 GDP tracking estimate at +1.8% (quarter-over-quarter annualized).

**US MAP:**

GDP 0 (4, 0)

Monthly personal spending -1 (1, -1)

Initial claims 0 (2, 0)

Continuing claims 0 (1, 0)

**KEY NUMBERS:**

GDP (advance estimate) +3.4% (QoQ AR) for Q3 vs. GS +3.3%, median forecast +3.2%, prior +2.2%

Personal consumption +3.8% (QoQ AR) for Q3 vs. GS +3.4%, median forecast +3.4%, prior +3.8%

Personal income +0.2% for September vs. GS +0.2%, median forecast +0.3%, prior revised +0.3%

Personal spending +0.5% for September vs. GS +0.4%, median forecast +0.6%, prior +0.9%

Core PCE price index +0.32% (MoM) for September vs. GS +0.34%, median forecast +0.3%, prior revised +0.3%

Core PCE price index +3.12% (YoY) for September vs. GS +3.11% median forecast

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+3.1%, prior +3.0%

PCE price index +0.49% (MoM) for September vs. GS +0.51%, median forecast +0.5%, prior +0.3%

PCE price index +3.65% (YoY) for September vs. GS +3.64%, median forecast +3.6%, prior +3.4%

Initial claims 194k for the week ended October 24 vs. GS 205k, median forecast 198k, prior revised 195k

Continuing claims 1,701k for the week ended October 17 vs. median forecast 1,720k, prior revised 1,722k

**MAIN POINTS:**

1. Real GDP grew 3.4% annualized in the third quarter, somewhat above consensus expectations, and the composition was strong. Consumer spending rose 3.8% annualized, above expectations. The consumer has remained resilient this year despite higher energy prices, and the outlook appears healthier following upward revisions to income and the saving rate in last month's annual revisions to the national accounts. However, we expect spending growth to slow from its recent rapid pace as the boost from fiscal stimulus earlier in the year fades completely and spending converges to the pace of real income growth. Nonresidential fixed investment rose 12.7% annualized, largely reflecting increases in the information processing equipment (+37.4%) and industrial equipment (+24.7%) components related to the AI buildout. Housing investment declined 3.3%, reflecting the drag from higher rates. Inventory accumulation added 1.6pp to GDP growth in Q3, while net trade subtracted 3.3pp, reflecting stronger imports and lower exports, partly due to a sharp decline in oil exports. The drop in oil exports was roughly neutral for Q3 GDP, however, as it largely reflected slower US Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) releases, which are subtracted from GDP via lower federal government spending. Because the *change* in the pace of SPR drawdowns is what matters for GDP growth, slower releases provided a positive impulse to federal spending. On net, government spending boosted Q3 GDP growth by 0.9pp.

2. Personal income increased 0.2% in September, slightly below consensus expectations. Year-over-year disposable personal income growth reached 4.6% in September. Personal spending rose 0.5% in September, slightly below consensus expectations. Real personal spending, however, was flat, reflecting a 0.2% increase in real services spending offset by a 0.3% decrease in real goods spending. The saving rate edged down by 0.2pp to 3.8% in September: this level is slightly below our model predictions that factor in strong balance sheets and low unemployment. As a result, we expect the saving rate to tick up slightly by end-2026 and reach 4.2% by end-2027.

3. The core PCE index increased +0.32% in September, in line with expectations, and the year-over-year rate increased 3.12%. We estimate that the Dallas Fed's trimmed mean PCE measure increased 0.23% month-over-month and 2.27% year-over-year. We continue to view the trimmed mean measure as a good guide to the underlying inflation trend because much of what is currently being trimmed reflects the one-off effects of tariffs, the energy shock, and AI-related price pressure and statistical mismeasurement.

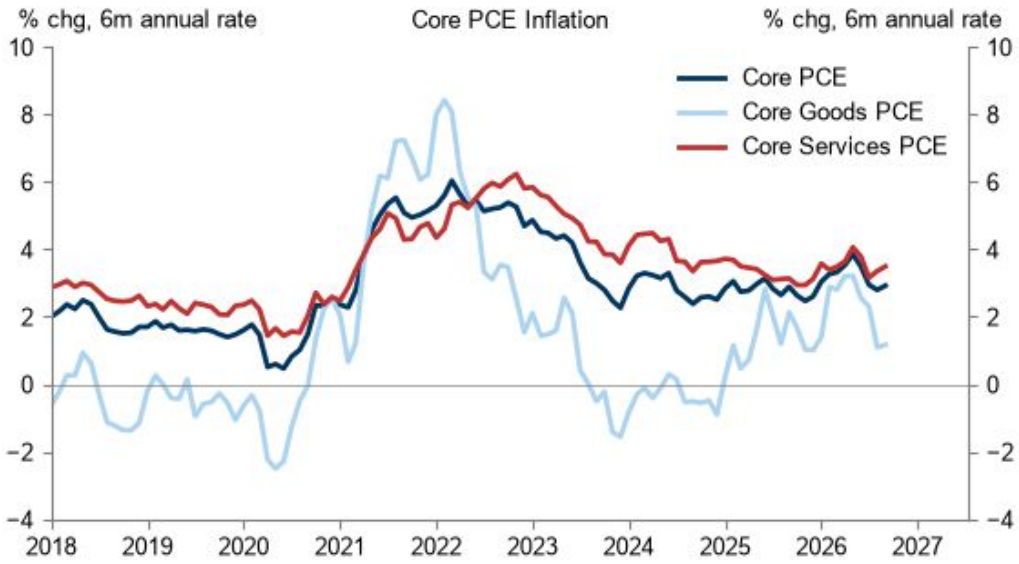
4. Initial jobless claims decreased by 1k to 194k in the week ended October 24, slightly below consensus expectations. The four-week moving average of claims decreased by



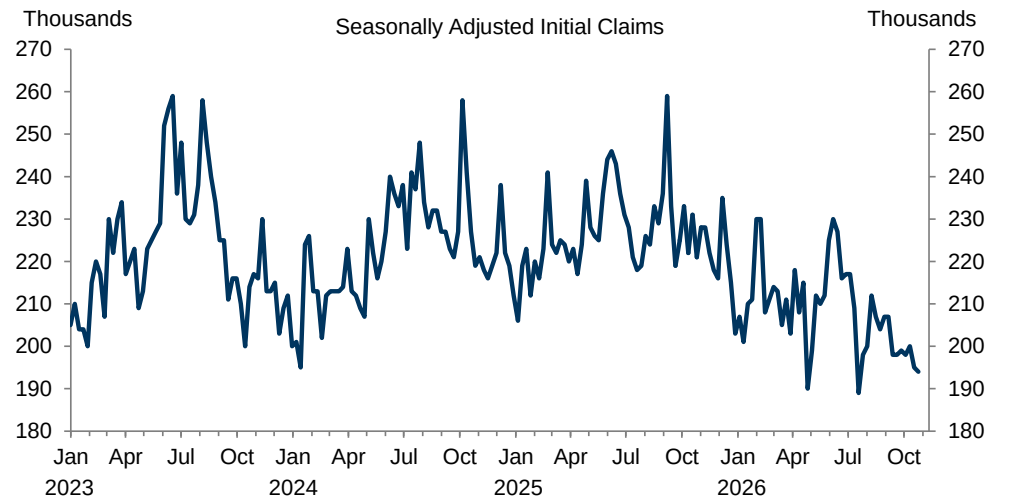
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1k to 197k, its lowest level since 1969. The very low level of jobless claims was highlighted by Chairman Warsh as an indicator of the strength of the labor market at the FOMC press conference yesterday. Claims increased by 4k in California and 2k in New York and decreased by 2k in Michigan (seasonally adjusted by GS). Nationwide continuing claims—the number of persons receiving benefits through standard programs—decreased by 21k in the week ended October 17, slightly below consensus expectations.

5. We launched our Q4 GDP tracking estimate at +1.8% (quarter-over-quarter annualized). We again expect a large decline in housing (-5.0%), a large increase in business fixed investment (+8.2%) driven by AI-related investment, and a more moderate pace of consumer spending growth (+1.8%).



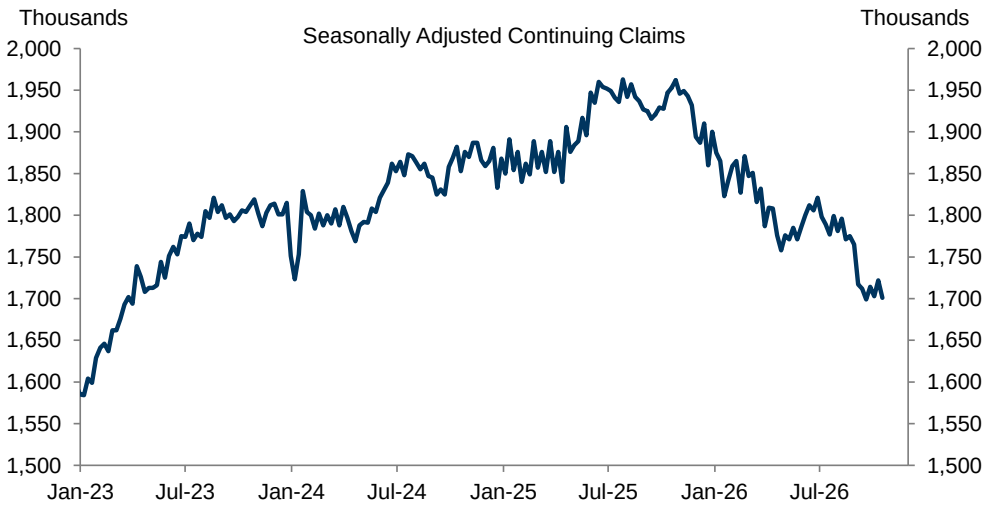

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Department of Commerce




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